

Part 1 of Start Strong– January 4, 2026

I. Welcome!

If you are a first-time guest or you are wanting to plug in more to weekly virtual prayer meetings, our Wednesday night small groups, serving, or membership–*Fill out our digital connect card to stay connected!*



II. Announcements:

See the additional vision handout for this week!

III. Start Strong – Part 1: Count the Cost

Jesus uses **building** and **warfare** to describe discipleship.

“For which of you, desiring to build a tower, doesn’t first sit down and count the cost...”
— *Luke 14:28–29 (WEB)*

- Foundations without foresight lead to unfinished lives and public loss.

“Or what king... will not sit down first and consider whether he is able...”
— *Luke 14:31 (WEB)*

- Battles without preparation are lost before they begin.

Jesus’ Conclusion

“So therefore whoever of you who doesn’t renounce all that he has, he can’t be my disciple.”
— *Luke 14:33 (WEB)*

- The cost is real.
- The cost is purposeful.
- Discipleship requires resolve, not impulse.

The Stakes of Not Counting the Cost

- Many fail not from rebellion, but from **under-preparation**.
- Resistance is guaranteed.
- Victory requires readiness before pressure arrives.

Story: Dieppe Raid (1942) – Cost Not Counted

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- Allied assault launched with poor intelligence and inadequate preparation.
 - Result: catastrophic losses and mission failure despite courage and numbers.

Story: Normandy (1944) – Cost Counted

- Two years of meticulous preparation shaped by Dieppe's failure.
- Result: sustained breakthrough and victory under immense pressure.

“For by wise guidance you will wage your war, and in the abundance of counselors there is victory.”
— *Proverbs 24:6 (WEB)*

Story: The Unfinished Tower – Ryugyong Hotel

- Massive project begun without long-term sustainability.
- Result: foundation laid, tower never finished, visible to all

Story: Building What Lasts – Empire State Building

- Built during the Great Depression with extreme planning and clarity.
- Result: finished ahead of schedule and still standing generations later.

“Through wisdom a house is built; by understanding it is established.”
— *Proverbs 24:3 (WEB)*

Why This Matters

- You are both **building a life** and **fighting a battle**.
- Neutral ground does not exist.

“For our wrestling is not against flesh and blood...”
— *Ephesians 6:12 (WEB)*

- Builders who prepare endure.
- Disciples who plan stand firm.

Personal Examination

- What will **finishing well actually require**?
- Have you prepared for resistance?
- What foundations are still missing?
- What groundwork have you delayed?

“So teach us to count our days, that we may gain a heart of wisdom.”
— *Psalms 90:12 (WEB)*